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Life and Death in a Congolese Ebola Ward
Caring for a patient at a medical clinic in Rwampara, the heart of the epidemic ravaging the Democratic Republic of Congo. Page A6.

Drying Reservoirs Threaten to Sap the Sun Belt

By SCOTT DANCE and MIRA ROJANASAKUL
Lakes Powell and Mead, the nation's largest reservoirs, are drying up, sending a Colorado River system that provides water and electricity for millions of people into a state of crisis with no end in sight.
Water levels in Lake Powell, along the Utah-Arizona border, fell to a record low on Saturday. Lake Mead, the larger of the two and farthest downstream on the Colorado River, dropped to its lowest recorded point a week earlier.
The combined reservoir system, an essential water source for cities and farms across Arizona, Nevada and Southern California,

Worst Drought in Over 1,000 Years Cuts Across 7 States

has not held so little water since 1957, before Lake Powell was filled. That was long before climate change brought three decades of drought, the worst dry spell for the Southwest in at least 1,200 years, scientists said.
Federal and state officials and communities across the region have taken emergency steps to try to head off catastrophe. They shifted water from a smaller reservoir to try to save Powell and have called for water conserva-

tion, though those requests are mostly voluntary so far.
The water shortage could have dire implications for growing Sun Belt cities such as Phoenix, for key industries including agriculture and data centers, and for hydroelectric dams that power millions of homes across the Southwest.
The shrinking reservoirs are the immediate result of record-low snowpack this winter, which was erased by record heat in the spring. Melted snowpack creates most of the Colorado's flow during the dry summer months. But as the Southwestern climate has grown hotter and drier, the river's flow has become smaller and less reliable.

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The Glen Canyon Dam in Arizona last month by Lake Powell. With Lake Mead, water is waning.

Farage Still Makes Room in Inner Circle for Convicted Fraudster

By MICHAEL D. SHEAR
LONDON — Before George Cottrell became famous in Britain as “Posh George,” a near-constant sidekick to the right wing politician Nigel Farage, he traveled to Las Vegas to meet with drug traffickers for whom he'd offered to launder money.
It was 2014, and Mr. Cottrell was 21. He had met the traffickers on the dark web. Under the pseudo-

nym “Bill,” he said he would take \$20,000, send it to offshore accounts, and return it clean. Later, according to a federal indictment filed in 2016, he threatened to extort the traffickers for the Bitcoin equivalent of \$80,000.
It was not until Mr. Cottrell was arrested at O'Hare International Airport in Chicago two years later that it became clear the drug dealers he had met in Las Vegas were actually I.R.S. agents conducting

A Return to Parliament With ‘Posh George’

a sting. On July 22, 2016, he and Mr. Farage were heading back to London after a whirlwind week at the Republican National Convention — where Mr. Farage was lauded for his role in Britain's recent Brexit vote — when five

Can Tax Boom From A.I. Era Fix U.S. Debt?

By ANDREW DUEHREN
WASHINGTON — Artificial intelligence could fundamentally change the nature of work and transform the U.S. economy. So its potential to alter the nation's admittedly troubled fiscal trajectory may seem niche.
Yet a growing number of economists have started to anticipate that widespread adoption of A.I. could structurally improve the imbalance between what America spends and what it collects in tax revenue in the coming years — as long as the technology does not put too many people out of work.
That is because A.I. could help make workers more productive, in turn growing the economy more rapidly. Faster economic growth would generate more tax revenue, helping to close the widening gap between what the government spends and the taxes it brings in.
Not that this would amount to a total fiscal utopia. Economists still expect the gross debt, now at about \$40 trillion, to continue to grow, just less quickly than it might have without A.I. Several factors could impede or even reverse any budgetary progress, including the possibility that the gains from A.I. are lightly taxed. And Congress could always splurge on spending increases or tax cuts, canceling out any fiscal gains.
“The faster productivity growth from A.I. is not going to solve our budget imbalance,” said Douglas Elmendorf, a former director of the nonpartisan Congressional Budget Office. “It will help the

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NEWS ANALYSIS
Stuck on Iran, Trump Turns Gaze to Kim

Hinting at Overture Despite Past Failure

By DAVID E. SANGER and ANTON TROIANOVSKI
The last time President Trump vowed to halt a country's nuclear weapons program, he held three face-to-face meetings with Kim Jong-un of North Korea, declared that the two men had developed a “great relationship” and walked away empty-handed.
That was in Mr. Trump's first term. Not only did the diplomatic effort fail, but Mr. Kim immediately hit the accelerator on his program and today possesses roughly 60 nuclear weapons, by some estimates, as well as missiles that appear capable of reaching the United States — exactly the combination Mr. Trump had vowed to dismantle.
For months now, proliferation experts have questioned whether Mr. Trump could also end up walking away from his efforts to check Iran's nuclear program — especially now that he appears to be more focused on getting the Strait of Hormuz open than on dealing with Iran's stockpiles of uranium, which are buried under rubble after the United States bombed them in June 2025.
Stymied in Iran, Mr. Trump is increasingly turning his sights back to North Korea, even though analysts see little hope of quickly dismantling that country's growing nuclear arsenal.
Mr. Trump's social media declaration on Sunday night, praising Mr. Kim and publicly ordering Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth to diminish America's role in an annual military exercise with South Korea, one of America's allies in the Pacific, appeared intended to signal that he wants to resume negotiations. A day later, it remained unclear just how the Pentagon would scale back its role in the 11-day exercise, and a one-line state-

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OIL GIANTS IN GULF SPRINT TO EXPAND RESERVES ABROAD

IRAN WAR CHOKES FLOW

Saudi Arabia and U.A.E. Seek Relief in Japan and South Korea

By RIVER AKIRA DAVIS
TOKYO — Middle Eastern energy giants are scrambling to move more oil into stockpiles safely beyond the turbulent Persian Gulf region, as a prolonged conflict forces exporters and their biggest customers to rethink how to safeguard supplies.
Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates have urged Japan to expand reserves in Japanese tanks by as much as 10 times the roughly eight million barrels each now holds, according to three people familiar with the discussions, who asked not to be identified because the talks are private.
Officials with Saudi Arabia and the Emirates are having similar discussions about expanding their oil stockpiles in South Korea as well, two of the people said.
For the Gulf exporters, which store much of their oil in the region, warehousing more crude abroad offers protection against maritime chokepoints that have become increasingly precarious, from Houthi attacks in the Red Sea to a Strait of Hormuz that shows little sign of opening. Saudi Arabia and the Emirates both have overland pipelines that bypass the strait and enable them to continue exporting limited amounts of oil.
For Asian nations, the world's largest consumers of Middle Eastern crude, bigger stockpiles would provide an additional buffer against prolonged supply disruptions.
At the same time, allocating significantly more tank capacity to foreign oil companies reduces the available space for domestic refiners' commercial inventories and

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DESIREE RIOS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Ghulam Kehar said he was afraid to leave his family behind in Irving, Texas, as he departed for a distant Coast Guard posting.

In Texas, Anti-Muslim Feelings Sharpen to a Brazen Campaign

This article is by J. David Goodman, Lauren McGaughy, Jesus Jiménez and Ruth Graham.
HOUSTON — Ghulam Kehar rose before dawn in early June to attend the day's first prayer at his local mosque in Irving, Texas, before heading off for a monthslong deployment with the U.S. Coast Guard.
He had been deployed before, but this time was different. He felt apprehensive about leaving his wife and four children behind in Texas, even for a short while.
Rhetorical attacks on Muslims by top Texas leaders had become more pronounced, and seemed to

be trickling down. At his mosque, the Valley Ranch Islamic Center, and others across the state, congregants and religious leaders swapped stories of ugly comments directed at them while praying in public or sitting in public parks.
In recent months, a man had been arrested and charged with making a terroristic threat at a major new Islamic center in Houston. Not far away, in Conroe, a woman told Muslim shoppers at a grocery store they were “not welcome in this state or this country” — after losing her job, she received nearly \$250,000 from sup-

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Primary-Night Showdowns
In Florida, voters are weighing in on races in redrawn districts. Coverage of those contests and primaries in Alaska and Wyoming is at nytimes.com.

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Trump's Border Wall Mission
By the end of next year, the president wants to finish the job, amounting to 1,200 miles of barriers. PAGE A11

Easing Fund-Raiser Emails
Google will enable verified campaigns to get past its spam filter, after complaints of bias by Republicans. PAGE A15



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Very Far Off Broadway
A Hudson Valley festival for lovers of musical theater featured singalongs, raves, campfires and merch. PAGE C1

Bending It Like ‘Ted Lasso’
The show's focus on female soccer players mirrors an increase in the popularity of women's sports. PAGE C1

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A Clash of French Elites
In a Provence village, the mayor closed a road, setting off a storm with residents and the owners of a castle that once belonged to his family. PAGE A4

West Bank Economy Troubles
Israeli curbs have hit every part of the territory, spurring fears over the Palestinian Authority's solvency. PAGE A9

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Learning to Let It Go
Packers Coach Matt LaFleur, known for his quicksilver mind, is trying to slow down after grieving a friend. PAGE B7

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China Lures Scientific Talent
Young researchers and mathematicians have long come to the United States for academic training, but a combination of Chinese money and U.S. restrictions is shifting the balance. PAGE B1

ABC Files Suit Against F.C.C.
The network asked a federal court to stop the regulatory agency from taking steps that could force stations off the air and accused the F.C.C. of violating its First Amendment rights. PAGE B1

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Michelle Goldberg PAGE A18



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Mexican Food on Main Street
The country's dynamic cuisine can be found all over the United States. Here's a look at its evolution and a list of some of the best places to find it. PAGE D1



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